Middle Section.—This follows immediately, the subject being presented in the alto in the key of F minor, with countersubject in the treble. The second and last episode (bars 26 to 32) is formed from the last member of the subject. The next appearance of the subject is at bar 32 in the tenor, in the unrelated key of E flat minor, and unaccompanied by the countersubject. The entry at bar 35 in the treble, in the key of B flat minor, may be regarded as the answer to the preceding, though real instead of tonal; the countersubject is in the alto. Next follows an entry in the bass in D flat (bar 37), with a portion of the countersubject in the treble.

Final Section.—The subject returns in the key of A flat in the tenor in bar 41, with the countersubject, curiously varied, in the treble; and is answered in stretto by the bass in bar 42. There is a coda from bar 46 to the end, containing an entry of the answer (but in the tonic key) in the tenor at bar 48, where a fifth voice is added, the first bass taking a part of the countersubject while the second supplies the harmonic bass.

Although nominally a four-part fugue, there is a great predominance of three-part writing, less than one-third of the whole being really in four parts.

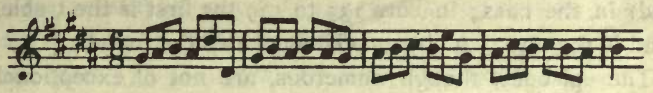
FUGUE 42 (Book II, 18)

G SHARP MINOR (THREE VOICES).

One of the longest and most elaborate of the forty-eight, although containing no stretto. It is virtually a double fugue, its second subject (or countersubject) having a separate exposition from bar 61 to 83, only slightly irregular at bars 71 to 75. Contrast the very irregular entries of the new themes in No. 38.
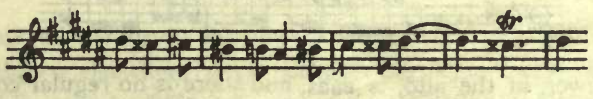
Ebenezer Prout: Analysis of J. S. Bach's Forty-Eight Fugues
Ed. Louis B. Prout. London: Edwin Ashdown, 1910. Printed pp. 78-80.
BWV 887. Complete original pages; adjoining commentary is retained.
Full source scan

First Section.—The subject is announced in the treble—



and takes a real answer (alto). There is a codetta from bar 9 to the end of bar 12, the subject entering in the bass at the beginning of bar 13. This completes the exposition proper, but it is noteworthy that all the four following entries (bars 19, 33, 45, 55) are in the original key. It would be possible to classify them as a redundant entry of the subject (bar 19) and a counter-exposition (bars 33 to 59), but the latter would be irregular, and it must be borne in mind that the three normal divisions of a double fugue of this class are: (1) treatment of first subject separately; (2) treatment of second subject separately; (3) treatment of both subjects combined.

Middle Section.—A new theme is announced in the treble from bar 61, in the dominant key:—



This is answered in the tonic by the alto (bar 66). The bass then introduces it in the **subdominant** instead of the dominant (bar 71) and there is a redundant entry in the treble in the tonic (bar 79).

Final Section.—After a longish episode, the two subjects are combined at bar 97, the first being in the bass, the second in the alto. In the answer to this (bar 103), the treble takes the first subject, the alto again taking the second. At bar 111 we have the only entry which is not in one of the original keys. Here the key is E, with the subjects in the two upper voices. The two remaining entries are in G sharp minor; in bars 125-129
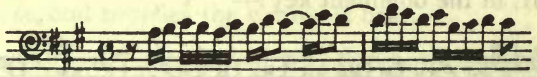
the first subject is in the alto, and the second (not quite completed) in the bass; in bars 135 to 139 the first is the treble, the second is the alto. A short coda concludes the fugue.

The episodes, though numerous, are not of exceptional importance. They are developed, as usual, from suggestions from the subject (as at bars 37 and 129), the countersubject (as at bars 115, etc.) or the codetta (as at bar 49, etc.). See bars 23 to 32, 37 to 44, 49 to 54, 84 to 96, 107 to 111, 115 to 124, 129 to 134.

FUGUE 43 (Book II, 19)
A MAJOR (THREE VOICES).

A melodious little fugue, of such simple construction as to call for hardly any special remarks.

Exposition.—The subject is announced in the bass:—



The answer, in the alto, is **real**, and there is no regular countersubject. The codetta (bar 4) is in sequence, made from the last part of the subject. The treble enters in bar 5 with the subject; the bass in bar 7 with a redundant entry of the answer.

Middle Section.—The middle entries follow the exposition almost immediately, the subject entering in the treble at bar 9, in the key of F sharp minor. This is answered in the alto in bars 12, 13, in C sharp minor. The first episode (bars 13 to 16) and all succeeding ones are founded on the same part of the subject as is the codetta. The next entry is in the key of A (bar 16, bass) and might have indicated the arrival of the final section of the fugue; but Bach here treats it rather as the dominant of the